

“Why are you so happy?” the king demanded. “What do you have to sing about?”

The blacksmith smiled. “It’s a bright, sunny day. I’m healthy, working at my trade. I have my wife, my children. Life offers beautiful things. I sing.”

“Do you have a home?” the king asked. “Food on the table? A sturdy horse?” (One might say the king was materialistic.)

The smith smiled and shook his head. “My family and I sleep on the ground, close to the earth, in a room connected to the stables. We have gruel to eat. It is enough.”

The king was so overwhelmed that he gave the man a bag of gold.

A few days later, the king passed by that way again but heard no singing. He went to see what had happened. He found a haggard blacksmith staring with wide, troubled eyes into a cold fire pit.

“I lie awake nights deciding what to buy,” the smith told the king. “I worry about where to hide my gold so no one will rob me. My wife and children fight about who will get to spend the money.” Desperation on his face, the smith pleaded with the king. “Won’t you please take back your gift?”

The king took the bag of gold. As he rode away he could hear the man singing, the happy sound once again echoing through the valley. The king was happy too. With the extra gold he could buy a few more countries or another dozen wives.

Aldo paused at the end of the story. “Does your book suggest we live more like the blacksmith?” he asked.

“Exactly.”

Aldo squinted a little. “But the blacksmith works.”

I said, “The blacksmith finds pleasure in the beauty around him. Sudden wealth took him away from those pleasures, not toward them. The blacksmith lives simply, but he’s in control of his life, doing exactly what he wants to do. Isn’t that the point of the story?”